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Cambridge O Level

ENGLISH LANGUAGE **1123/11**

Paper 1 Reading **May/June 2026**

INSERT **2 hours**

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INFORMATION

- This insert contains the reading passages.
- You may annotate this insert and use the blank spaces for planning. **Do not write your answers** on the insert.

This document has **8** pages. Any blank pages are indicated.

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Read **Text A** and answer **Question 1** and **Question 2** on the question paper.

Text A: Moving to Canada

The writer's father was the founder and owner of a zoo in India, where the writer spent his early childhood.

1 It was a huge zoo, spread over many acres.

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I was safe.

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Read **Text B** and answer **Question 3** on the question paper.

Text B: Living in a smart home

Imagine being shaken gently awake by your bed mattress. With a simple voice command, your shower automatically turns on to your preferred 38° Celsius. You tap an app; the kitchen stirs into life and the noise of grinding coffee beans can be heard. Such a comforting scenario no longer belongs to the world of science fiction because now we have the smart home – an automated home equipped with multiple devices connected through one central smart hub.

Smart home technology provides homeowners with all sorts of advantages. For instance, when you lock your smart lock, a smart home hub can tell your lights to turn off and your thermostat to go into eco mode, ensuring more efficient energy use. Thanks to artificial intelligence, a smart home learns about its occupants and anticipates their needs, storing information about their routines and habits, including what music they prefer to listen to in the morning and what lighting is required in each room. 'It even tells me what films I might like,' says smart home enthusiast Sam Gurung, 'and that saves me time.'

Recent research indicates that smart home technology increases property value, but this technology is not cheap. It also depends on reliable Wi-Fi and secure passwords; those who are not very tech-confident may find the technology a bit overwhelming. Nor is everyone happy about smart devices collecting information about the home's occupants. 'It's a bit creepy,' says Alex Lee, a friend of Sam Gurung. 'From the moment I ring Sam's doorbell, I feel like my privacy's being invaded. It's not how I'd choose to live my life. Can't Sam choose his own films to watch?'

When a smart home is empty, it's still very much alive. Motion sensors, surveillance cameras and video doorbells linked to a smartphone allow us to monitor our home even when we're not in it. 'I once saw someone suspicious looking through a window at home when I was out in a restaurant one evening, and I immediately activated all our garden lighting to come on. They disappeared very quickly,' laughs Sam.

Integral to every smart home is a voice-activated smart assistant speaker. These smart assistants are often given a gender, a name – and can organise family life. 'Ours is wonderful,' enthuses Sam. 'She tells us the weather and books cinema tickets. She's an encyclopaedia of knowledge and is a real help when our son's struggling with homework. She's like a home tutor. She even tells our four-year-old bedtime stories – all I have to do is ask! My friend Alex doesn't approve for some reason.'

The benefits of smart homes are not just for the tech-savvy youngsters. They're proving to be invaluable for allowing the older generation to live with more independence in their own homes, and people are reassured that their ageing friends and family members are safe.

As physical activity and sleep are good overall health predictors, sensors in chairs and wearable trackers can deliver helpful daily insights into exactly how much activity we do. Bed sensors in mattresses can track sleep patterns, breathing rate and heartbeat, and this home health monitoring can only be a plus.

And of course, any truly smart kitchen is bursting with technological devices. In a world where so much household food is thrown away, the smart home is mindful of waste. 'Sometimes I feel I'm being told off by my fridge!' says Sam, referring to his smart fridge's ability to alert its owner to the expiry dates on food. 'Then maybe you should just check for yourself,' suggests Alex.

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